

Where Does the Revenue Actually Come From?

A revenue comparison across all 29 categories of 1,000 bootstrapped startups.

1,000

startups

29

categories

\$15.60M

earned in 30 days

\$133.75M

earned in 12 months

THE HEADLINE

Revenue is **extremely concentrated.**

Just three categories capture 31% of all 30-day revenue. The remaining 26 categories split what's left.

#1

AI

\$2.36M

30-day revenue

197 startups

#2

Marketing

\$1.32M

30-day revenue

42 startups

#3

E-comm

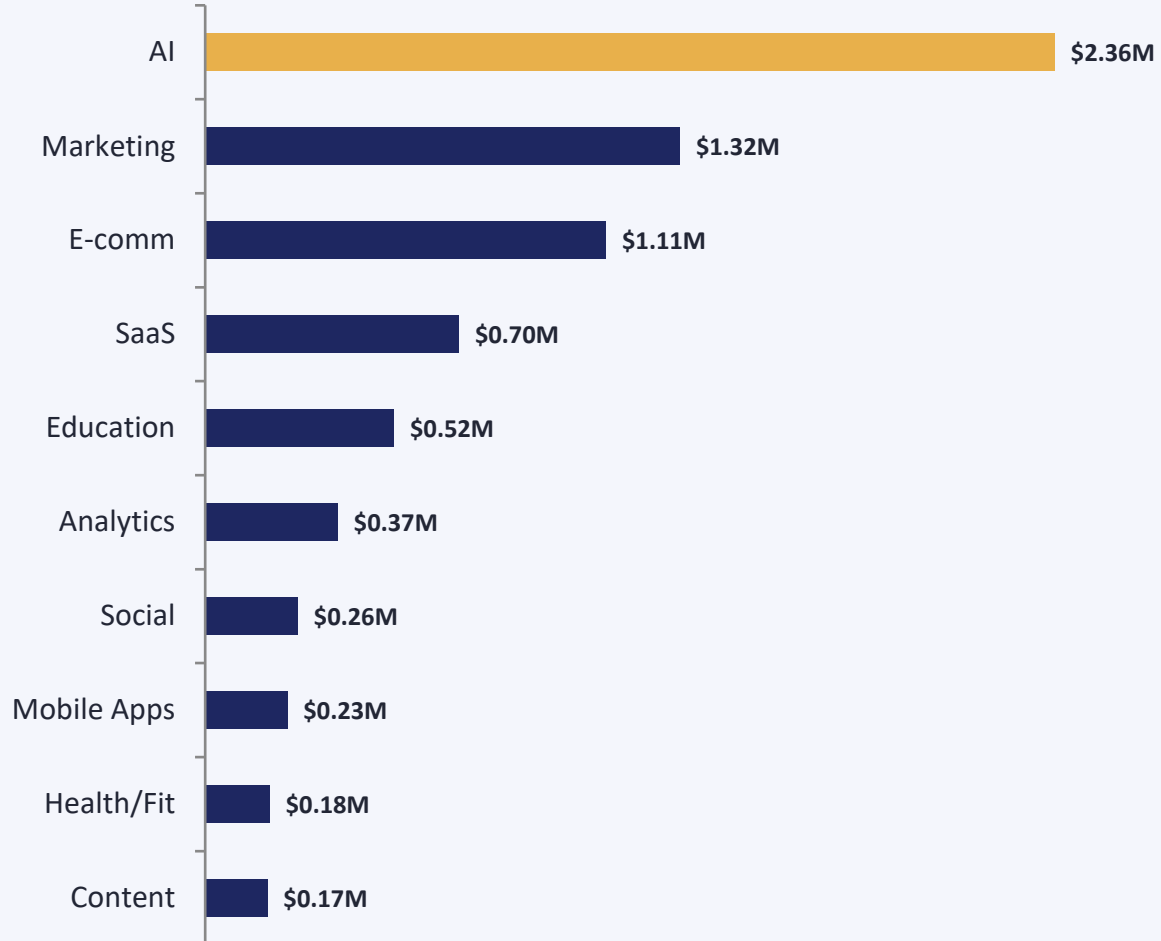
\$1.11M

30-day revenue

19 startups

The rest of this report unpacks what that concentration hides — and where the real money-per-founder is.

Which categories earn the most?



READ THIS

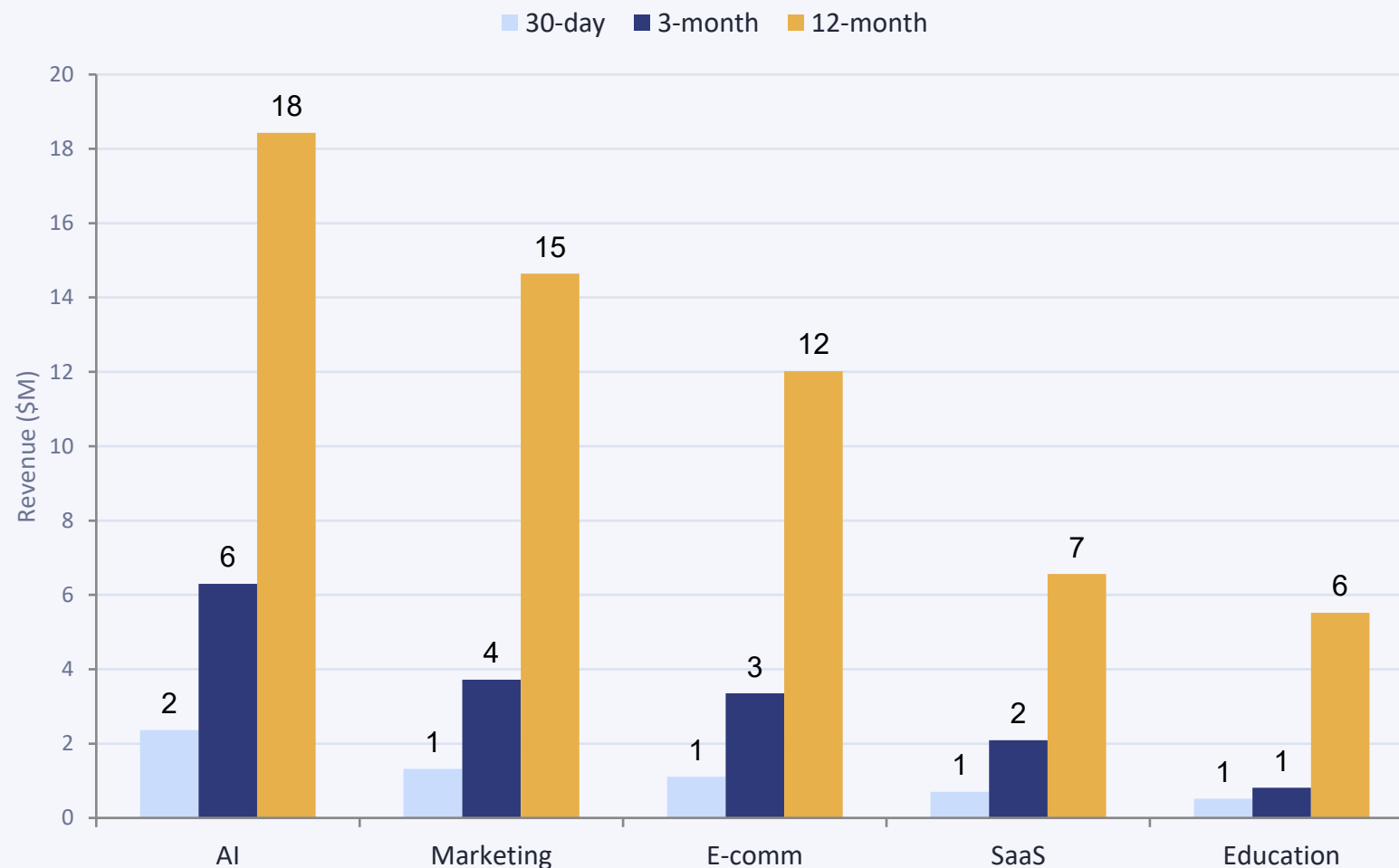
AI alone earns more than the next two categories combined.

But volume ≠ wealth.

AI has 197 startups sharing that pot. The next slides show what each founder actually takes home.

SAME REVENUE, THREE TIME WINDOWS

Category revenue compounds over the year



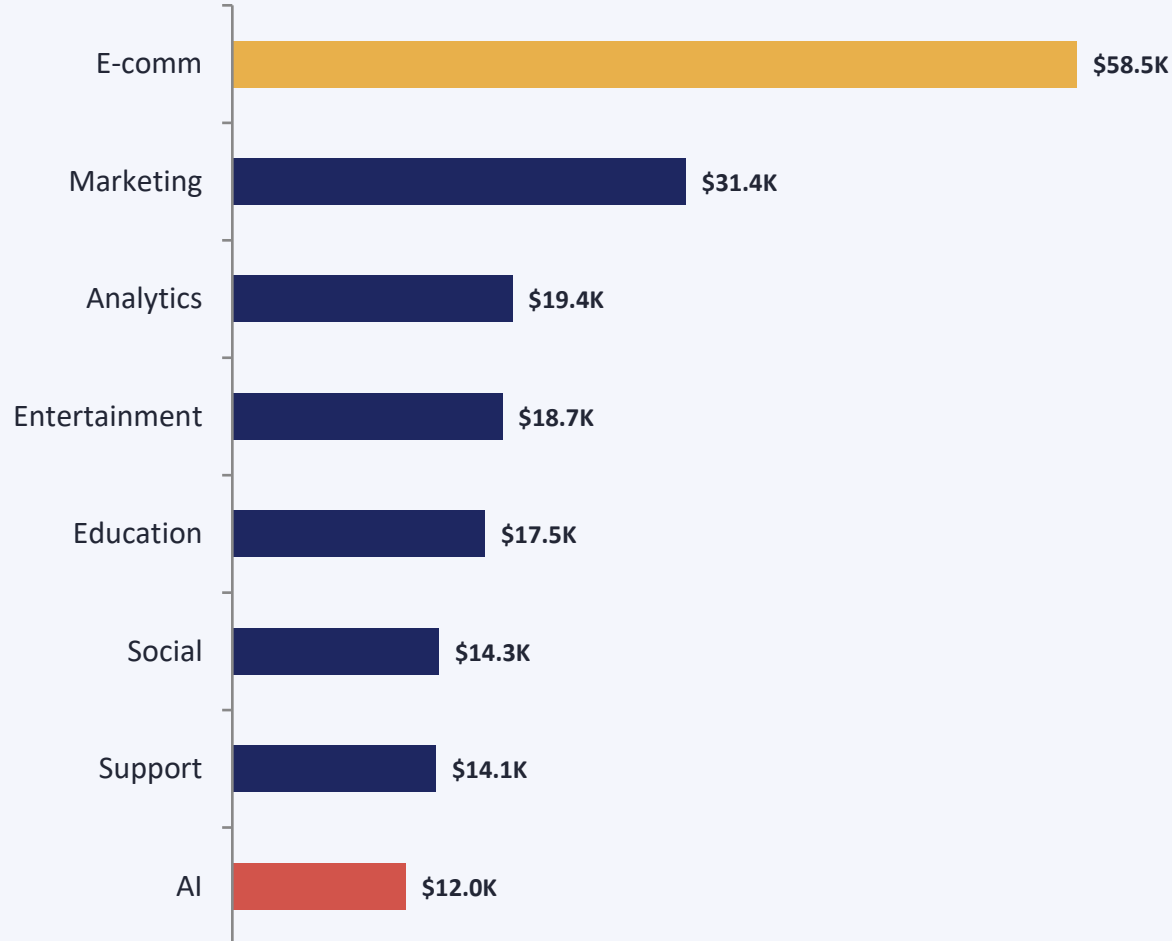
8.6×

total revenue growth
from the 30-day to the
12-month window

*A \$1K / month category becomes
roughly \$8.6K over a year.*

TOTAL REVENUE ÷ NUMBER OF STARTUPS

The richest category isn't the biggest one



THE TWIST

E-comm earns **\$58.5K** per startup — from just 19 companies.

AI sits near the bottom at **\$12.0K** each, despite leading on total revenue.

Fewer competitors, stronger unit economics.

Three leaders, three different ways to win

AI

WINS BY VOLUME

Startups

197

30-day revenue

\$2.36M

12-month revenue

\$18.43M

Revenue / startup

\$12.0K

Avg followers

4,560

Avg MRR

\$9.2K

Marketing

WINS BY EFFICIENCY

Startups

42

30-day revenue

\$1.32M

12-month revenue

\$14.64M

Revenue / startup

\$31.4K

Avg followers

6,611

Avg MRR

\$10.6K

E-comm

WINS BY WEALTH

Startups

19

30-day revenue

\$1.11M

12-month revenue

\$12.02M

Revenue / startup

\$58.5K

Avg followers

14,852

Avg MRR

\$20.8K

CORRELATION WITH 30-DAY REVENUE

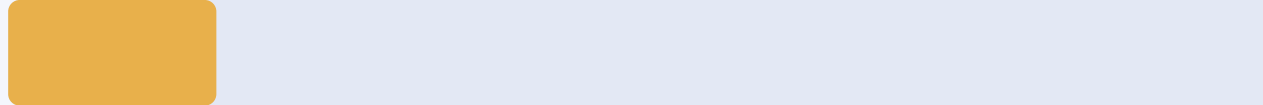
What actually predicts revenue?

Active subscriptions



0.802

Site visitors



0.164

X followers



0.024

Myth-buster: followers barely move revenue (0.02). Paying subscribers are the real engine (0.80). Build the product, not the audience.

THE REALITY CHECK

Most revenue sits with a few winners

30-DAY REVENUE, BY QUARTILE

Top 25%

> \$5.5K / mo

Upper-mid

\$400 – \$5.5K

Lower-mid

\$9 – \$400

Bottom

25%

< \$9 / mo

THE EXIT MARKET IS LIVE

26.2%

of startups are
currently for sale

262 of 1,000 companies

\$335.1K

average asking price for a bootstrapped startup on the
market

250 startups per band. The median startup earns just \$399 / month.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

Five things the revenue data tells us

- 1 Concentration is real** Top 3 categories = 31% of revenue; 26 others share the rest.
- 2 Volume $\neq$ wealth** AI leads on total revenue but earns only \$12.0K per startup.
- 3 E-comm is the quiet winner** \$58.5K per startup from just 19 companies.
- 4 Subscribers, not followers** Subscriptions predict revenue (0.80); followers don't (0.02).
- 5 The market is liquid** 26% are for sale at ~\$335.1K on average.